Big Brother is home. He is installed in the item you just dragged home from the Apple Store.

That was the threat, and we applied ourselves to it, quite frankly, while everyone else was still trying to work out how to spell email. As I say, it's taken tremendously for granted by everyone: people who send a hundred emails a day and never worry, kids who live on Facebook, but these things had to be invented, and the governments at the time were reluctant to allow ordinary Internet users to encrypt freely. Governments, especially the US government, wanted a back door into the system. They were working for a military understanding of surveillance, and the early Internet, the early forms of electronic mail, presented issues they wanted control over. But the cryptographers stuck with it and now we have an Internet relatively free of government interference, unless you happen to live in China.

I was moving towards this – the dissolving of my hacker instincts into something more mathematical, more purposeful – when the hacking case finally came to court in 1996. My two friends in the International Subversives, Prime Suspect and Trax, had suffered differently since the raid. For Prime Suspect it was the short joy of Ecstasy and the long misery of coming down, ending in paranoia and depression, and the slow unravelling, with the help of a counsellor, of his relationship with his mother and of his feelings about the death of his father. For Trax, it was panic attacks. His downward spiral had started well before the raid, and led to it, indeed. He was in a car crash that left him constantly fearful. In her book *Underground* – which I had helped research in the intervening years – Suelette reports that Trax at this point was reduced to fully-fledged agoraphobia. That was about the size of it. The police raid brought us all low. We all vanished for a time into a private hell, all in our early twenties, badly marked for too little reason, it seemed. The charges were shuffled around. There was a terrible kind of ignorant glee going on within the press at the time. They didn't know what the offences meant and they had built up a ridiculous picture of the threat posed by these teenage boys. In reality, ours was just a grubby little case of too much obsession and too much curiosity and not enough care; but it was turned into something of epic, state-threatening proportions by a bunch of lunatic prosecutors and media slags who should have known better.

I wrote something on the cypherpunk mailing list in January 1996 that captures my disgust at the time. My comments related to the felling of